Black Pearl Sings!

By Frank Higgins

Setting: a warden's office at a prison farm during a fierce Texas summer day in 1933. Susannah is packing up to leave, but hesitates when she hears Pearl

PEARL: ***(Pg 147-149)*** *(Pearl begins to sing Off stage)* ***Down on me, Lord, Down on me. Seems like everybody in this whole wide world is down on me. Down on me, dear Lord, Down on me.***

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6Br7GDLbxqo

SUSANNAH: Hey! I want whoever that is singing brought in here. *(Pearl enters in black and -white prison strips. Her ankles are shackled together, and she carries a ball and chain.)*

PEARL: You be on the parole board? Don't let this thing fool you; I be a good person.

SUSANNAH: No, I don't give paroles – It's okay to look me in the eye. What's your name?

PEARL: Alberta Johnson. Friends call me Pearl.

SUSANNAH: Why you're in prison is none of my business. But you sing better than the other women. My name is Susannah Mullally; I work for the Library of Congress. I go around the country to find songs from the ***people***. I've found that prisons are a good place to look for old songs. My biggest dream is to find a song that goes back **before** slavery time; that came here from Africa.

INTRODUCTION

Actress playing Pearl: *It's 1933, and an ambitious song collector for the Library of Congress visits a Texas prison*
Actress playing Savannah: *There she meets Pearl, an African-American woman with a soulful voice and steely spirit.*
Actress playing Pearl: *This play explores what it means to be black in a white world*
Actress playing Savannah: *A woman in a man's world, and fighting for one's soul in a world where anyone can be a commodity.*
Together: *Black Pearl Sings! By Frank Higgins*

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SUSANNAH: **(Pg 149-151)** If I can find a song that came here on the slave ships, you know what that would do? We can prove to the world that a song can be stronger than even slavery chains. Were either of your parents slaves?

PEARL: Yessum. [But] I don't wanna sing to no private. I wanna sing to a general who can do somethin' for me. And since you want somethin' I got . . . *(Pearls starts to leave)*

SUSANNAH: Wait. Wait! . . . **(Pg 153)** Do you know any old songs or not?

PEARL: I know some play songs I learnt when I was a chil'. My mama learnt 'em when she was a girl too.

SUSANNAH: That get us back to slavery time. **(Pg 156)** I think you sang that song "Down on Me" knowing I'd hear it, knowing I'd like it, knowing I'd invite you in here. **(Pg 155)** Sing me the oldest song you know.

PEARL: **(Pg 156-157)** *(sings – Troubles so Hard)* ***Oh Lawdy now, troubles so hard / Don't nobody know my troubles but God / Went in the room, didn't stay long, looked on the bed and mother was dead. Oh Lawdy now, troubles so hard.***

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r9SENzRLk_M

SUSANNAH: Well, I guess I better get some men to lug in that recording machine.

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SUSANNAH: **(Pg 159)** *(excited)* The people at the Library of Congress listened to the recordings we made. *(reads a telegram to Pearl)* "Oh, Susannah, all of us here thrilled!" – exclamation point – "Pearl is a pearl. Authentic doorway to the past. Make more recordings ASAP"

PEARL: **(Pg 160)** I ain't makin' no more recordin's for you. **(Pg 161)** You tell me how you come to be here. Or you get nothin' more from me.

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SUSANNAH: [When I started] . . I haul that machine up into the Southern mountains on a mule, alone. The other song collectors are too afraid they'll get shot. I turn in the recording to the man in charge. He sends it to D.C. But he takes credit for it.

PEARL: Why you didn't tell folks the way it was?

SUSANNAH: I did. But he was older – well-known. He was a man. I thought I'd be the first woman to get a job at Harvard. I'd be able to send out a hundred collectors to save songs. Instead, he gets the Ivy League job and I get offered ten dollars a month if I'll be quiet.

PEARL: **(Pg 162)** How this be anything but bad news for me? You an outcast.

SUSANNAH: I have a plan – **(Pg 163)** gets you out of her legally. **(Pg 164)** Get you a parole. We write up a convincing case to the governor. We point out that you are a model prisoner and that you are a doorway to our past. The governor would be happy to have one less mouth to feed. The governor is more inclined to parole a woman who has gentle qualities. What are you in for?

PEARL: I took a knife and killed a man. *(Susasnnah looks stricken)* **(Pg 165)** But I wouldn't kill no man 'less he needed it.

SUSANNAH: *(taken aback for a moment)* Well . . . we'll try to make that a positive. **(Pg 168)** We'll record a song just for the governor. **(Pg 169)** Make it a good choice: we'll only get one chance.

PEARL: . . . There be an old song we sung in the cotton fields when I was a young'un. This be what the slaves be singin' together in the field. Maybe in the fields owned by the ancestors of this gov'ner. *(Pearl sings "Reap What you Sow")* ***You Gonna Reap What you Sow / Sowin' on the mountain, sowin' in the valley/ You will reap just what you sow*** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rNB7nbbFDjI

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SUSANNAH: **(Pg 172)** The governor is looking over you file right now. He'll make his decision within the hour.

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PEARL: **(Pg 176)** Pray with me, Miss Susannah?

SUSANNAH: It's just . .. . when I used to pray, the things I prayed for, I never got them.

PEARL: Maybe God did answer your prayers. But his answer was no. . . I say somethin' wrong?

SUSANNAH: What is it with people who pary all the time? You think God sits around and says, "Ah, Pearl is thanking me for . . . God doesn't care.

PEARL: My God cares.

SUSANNAH: **(Pg 177)** As an adult, there's what I've learned: if I have to pray, then I haven't done enough preparation. Preparation is my way of praying. If we get the parole, it will be because of my preparation. If I have to pray, then I didn't prepare well enough.

PEARL: What you pray for before? To be a wife and mother?

SUSANNAH: Why would I want to be married? And end up like my mother?

PEARL: But with no kids, when you die you don't just die. You die out.

SUSANNAH: Not if the songs I've save live on

PEARL: Ah'm gonna sing now. Lord, I'm not askin' you this for my soul, but for Miss Susannah. *(Pearl sings)* **(Pg 178)** ***Do Lord, Do Lord, Lord, Remember Me.***

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=g-etAyjh9co

SUSANNAH: *(Susannah interrupts)* Pearl, Don't

PEARL: ***Do Lord, Do Lord, Lord, Remember me.***

SUSANNAH: *(Susannah interrupts)* I want you to stop.

PEARL: ***Do Lord, Do Lord, Lord, Remember me.***

SUSANNAH: I told you to stop it, didn't I?! It's a beautiful song. We'll record it. You can sing it ***for*** me then. But don't you dare sing it ***about*** me

PEARL: **(Pg 179)** Why you think you don't deserve God's love? *(the telephone rings and startles the women – Susannah answers)*

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SUSANNAH: **(Pg 182-183)** *(on the phone)* Hello? – Yes. Let me have it --- *(listens and give Pearl the thumbs-up signal)* Thank you. I want the parole to start today. The women will be working on a chain gang clearing out a swamp. *(Pause)* You're sentencing this great singer to three days of leeches! *(Pause)* No, your'e right. It's foolish of me to question you. I'm sorry. Yes, we still want the parole . . . Yes *(Susannah hangs up)*

PEARL: Thank you, Miz Susannah.

SUSANNAH: Pearl, your parole is not unconditional. I made a case to the governor that you are special. So there are things that we're supposed to do during your parole.

PEARL: **(Pg 184)** So what are the strings?

SUSANNAH: It's important to present you, and your songs, to people who matter. **(Pg 185)** The governor expects us to go to New York. **(Pg 184)** The real power is in New York.

PEARL: **(Pg 185)** I be a free woman. I go wherever I want to now and the gov'ner won't know.

SUSANNAH: Not exactly. **(Pg 186)** You've been paroled into my custody.

PEARL: So I be your slave girl now.

SUSANNAH: You are not a slave. And don't you ever say that to me.

PEARL: I have to go where you say? Do what you say? That be a slave

SUSANNAH: Everything I've done is to help you.

PEARL: And help yourself too. I ain't goin' to no New York. What you gonna do? Put me back in prison? *(Silence while Pearl considers her options)* There are only two kinds of people in this world. There's a few people who look to the future, and there's everybody else. So maybe I look to the future too. I'll go to New York.

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SUSANNAH: **(Pg 208)** *(Off stage – Voice Over by way of introduction)* Just as Paul and Silas were imprisoned but then sang and were set free, so has Pearl Johnson been

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set free. And this pearl is real; She's a black pearl, and the Black Pearl Sings! **(Pg 196)** *(Actresses step up to the apron and the sound of an audience applauding is heard)*

SUSANNAH: *(To the audience)* Thank you. For the final song of the night, we've chosen one that was composed after the Civil War. Its author is lot to history, and the song was almost lost as well. But thanks to Pearl, the song and the people it is sung about live one. And thanks to the Carnegie Foundation's grant to the Library, it will live forever.

PEARL: **(Pg 199)** *(Sings)* ***Kum ba yah . . . . . kum ba yah . . . .*** *(This does not sound corny like the "Kum Ba Ya" that contemporary audiences know). (Pearl explains)* These be words that mean "come by here." *(Susannah joins to the song and both begin to clap, stomp and move the music in celebration. Susannah has opened her heart to the Lord and shows it in her singing)* ***Me Mother need you lord, (Kum ba Yah) Me Father need you, lord (Kum ba Yah) Me Daughter need you, Lord (Kum ba Yah) Oh Lord Kum Ba Yah.***

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XxzO4jByMvY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Frank Higgins
Book: Plays for Two
ISBN: 978-0345804549
Publisher: Vintage
Date (Month/Year): March 2014

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier

****NOTE: Links are provided for each song so actresses can hear the rhythms and melodies***

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